would change enormously in the coming decades. In the meantime, when the caravan halted at Jalalabad, news reached the travellers of the murder of Tardi Beg by Bairam Khan and they took careful stock of Bairam Khan's ambitions.

Munim Khan, who was leading the imperial caravan, was a Turki Chaghatai nobleman like Tardi Beg and an old favourite of the harem. Munim Khan and the women would have understood that this murder was an indication of the subtle game of realignment that had been played by Akbar's new ataliq. They would have heard of all the ways in which Bairam Khan had neutralized the Turani nobility in Hindustan—by imprisoning and executing the few who openly opposed him and distributing largesse to those who were more complaisant. Munim Khan judged it prudent not to confront Bairam Khan at the moment and turned back towards Kabul while the caravan, now under the guardianship of Shamsuddin Ataka Khan, continued on its slow march. Along the way, Hamida Banu suffered personal tragedy when her two young daughters died, as young children did with terrifying regularity at the time. Now the only child she had left was Akbar, and he was to become the lodestone of her life and the focus of her considerable talent and energies.

Meanwhile Akbar and the Mughal army had left Delhi as Sikandar Shah had once again gathered some disaffected Afghans and zamindars and was stirring rebellion in the Punjab. Following the defeat of Hemu, most of these Afghans just moved further east to Bihar and Bengal, ruminating resistance. Hunting along the way and 'indulging in recreation and pleasure', the Mughal forces chased Sikandar Shah back to his fortress at Mankot. As the siege of Mankot dragged on for months, Akbar was able to spend a great deal of time with his beloved elephants, even riding the mast bull elephants when they were charging each other. Decades later Akbar would remember the name of the first bull elephant he had controlled in this way—Jhalpa.

It was while the siege of Mankot was underway that news arrived of the imminent arrival of the caravan from Kabul. Maham Anaga was sent ahead to Lahore to greet the party and it was outside Mankot that Akbar was reunited once again with his mother, Hamida Banu, his aunts, and his milk mothers. The Mughal camp was suddenly filled with effervescence and clamour as the soldiery, 'who had grown homesick during the long drawn-